



2008 Bronze Effie Winner

“Men With Cramps”

Category: **Healthcare – Products & Services**

Brand: **ThermaCare**

Client: **Proctor & Gamble**

Primary Agencies: **Publicis USA, Bridge Worldwide**

Media Agency: **SMG/Mediavest**

Contributing Agencies: **DeVries Public Relations, Kirt Gunn & Associates**

Strategic Challenge

ThermaCare Menstrual is a portable heat wrap designed to help relieve the pain of menstrual cramps. At 10% of total brand volume, it is the smallest product within the ThermaCare line, and has been declining for two years in a row. The product lacks the size and scale to make an impact in the marketplace – too little in marketing support, poor impact on shelf – suffers from a significant competitive disadvantage in terms of value, and finds itself increasingly in the shadow of the larger base ThermaCare business (muscle/joint).

The menstrual category is a mature, high cost-of-entry business dominated by large, heavy-spending brands such as Kotex, Always and Tampax. These brands have created strong consumer franchises and well-established conventions based on traditional notions of femininity and cleanliness. In terms of menstrual pain relief, again, large brands such as Advil, Tylenol and Motrin dominate the category but have provided little innovation or news. In total, it is a quiet, sleepy business dominated by a few powerful players happy to keep doing business as usual.

Marketing communication for ThermaCare Menstrual had come out of the base brand campaign, focusing on the overall brand benefit (portable heat), and little on the specific needs of the menstrual pain sufferer. Our research showed that there was large proportion of women (40%) who deal with significant and often debilitating levels of pain from menstrual cramps every month,

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and that these women were finding current treatments to be inadequate. Further, they found category messaging and cues to be off-putting and irrelevant to the reality of the pain they deal with every month.

So, the opportunity was there for us, if we could find a way to connect with women in a new and unique way and convey the innovative benefit of ThermaCare's heat wrap. We needed to do something that would break through the ossified marketplace and the dominant presence and spending of the big brands, and begin to carve out a unique identity for the ThermaCare Menstrual business.

Objectives

1. Stabilize the business – specifically, reverse the sales decline by at least 50%.
2. Generate consumer dialog about menstrual pain and ThermaCare. We had no history to enable us to specifically quantify this goal. Our key success markers included on-line chat, blog mentions, Google search entries and editorial mentions.

The Big Idea

"Give women the vicarious, cathartic pleasure of watching MEN deal with the pain of menstrual cramps."

The idea sprang from two places. First, with limited presence and investment, we knew we had to do something completely unconventional. Second, as we talked to women we saw a deep level of frustration about the lack of understanding of their menstrual pain. Time and again we heard women say, "If only my boyfriend had to deal with this every month ...", and so we realized that men offered the perfect foil to women's pain. Women universally believe that men are wimps when it comes to pain.

Bringing the Idea to Life

Men With Cramps was a viral campaign grounded in the (fake) clinical study of the mysterious medical condition known as "Cyclical Non-uterine Dysmennorrhea" (otherwise known as male menstrual cramps).

The campaign was executed in four phases over a 6-month period:

- First, we launched a 'call for volunteers' to a clinical study on Cyclical Non-uterine Dysmennorrhea via small-space print ads running in alternative newspapers such as the Village Voice;
- Second, we launched a website detailing the efforts of the MacInness and Porritt Institute and its lead researcher Dr. Gerhardt Fardel in battling this little known disorder;

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- Third, we launched a series of documentary films on-line (webisodes) chronicling Dr. Fardel's efforts and the struggles of his research subjects.
- Fourth, we introduced a new branded micro-site dedicated to ThermaCare Menstrual, and on-line advertising (search and banners) to drive people to our brand and the content.

On-line was the focus for us because we wanted to get people deeply engaged with our content, make it easy for them to pass it along, and to get them talking about the idea in blogs and chatrooms. We felt the internet was the best place to leverage the outrageousness of the campaign idea, allowing people to discover it organically and spread the idea across their social networks.

Communications Touch Points

☐ TV ☐ Spots ☐ Branded Content ☐ Sponsorship ☐ Product placement ☒ Radio ☐ Spots ☐ Merchandising ☒ Program/content ☒ Print ☐ Trade/Professional ☒ Newspaper ☐ Consumer Magazine ☐ Print partnership ☐ Direct ☐ Mail ☐ Email ☒ PR ☐ Events	☐ Packaging ☐ Product Design ☐ Cinema ☒ Interactive ☒ Online Ads ☒ Web site ☒ Viral video ☐ Video skins/bugs ☒ Social Networking sites ☐ Podcasts ☐ Gaming ☐ Mobile Phone ☐ Other _____ ☐ OOH ☐ Airport ☐ Transit ☐ Billboard ☐ Place Based ☐ Other _____	☐ Trade Shows ☐ Sponsorship ☐ Retail Experience ☐ POP ☐ Video ☐ In-Store Merchandizing ☐ Sales Promotion ☐ Retailtainment ☐ Guerrilla ☐ Street Teams ☐ Tagging ☐ Wraps ☐ Buzz Marketing ☐ Ambient Media ☐ Sampling/Trial ☒ Consumer Involvement ☒ WOM ☐ Consumer Generated ☒ Viral
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Additional Marketing Components:

Couponing (2,013 were distributed via the Menstrual Mini-Site)

Reach:

Local, Regional and National

Total Media Expenditure:

\$1 – 2 Million

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Results

1. We reversed the incoming sales decline by 58%.

ThermaCare Menstrual Volume Trend		
FY 05/06	FY 06/07	Index vs. YAG
- 7.2%	- 3.0%	(58)

Source: P&G/ThermaCare Brand

2. We generated significant involvement with the content – we got people talking about the issue of menstrual pain and ThermaCare.

The conversation was catching on and we saw evidence of this in the following:

- The campaign generated 1.3 million video views on iFilm and YouTube*
- Google search entries at height of the campaign were at 228,000***
 - The majority of people visited MenWithCramps.com with no referral - meaning that they typed it into their browser window (52%).**
- Attention garnered in high profile editorial/broadcast media: Jay Leno's Tonight Show, Article in the New York Times, segment feature on CNBC's "On The Money", Glamour.com, Rollingstone.com and Businessweek.com
- Total blog/chat-room mentions came to over 15,000****
- Banner ads achieved high click-through rates for Men With Cramps and the Menstrual Mini-Site (0.45% and 0.35%, respectively, while industry average is 0.2%)**
- ThermaCare branded link on Men With Cramps achieved a 6.3% click-through rate in January, 2007.**
- This led them to the pass-it-on page; the number of visitors to the pass it on page on ThermaCare Menstrual continued to grow over time, doubling from December to January.**

Sources

* SMG/MediaVest

** Urchin

*** Google (see screenshot in reel)

**** Nielsen Blogpulse

Anything else going on that might have helped drive results?

The business continued to lose distribution and trade support during this campaign. Had distribution held steady, we might have moved the business into the plus column.

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